

How Far Can They Walk Alone?

A short piece on independence, closeness, and the causative verbs that describe both — make, let, get, have, help. Written about two countries that answer the same question very differently: Brazil and Japan.

STUDENT

DATE

TEACHER

ARTICLE

At 7:15 on a Tokyo morning, a six-year-old in a yellow cap gets on the subway by himself, backpack half his size, and rides four stops to school. No parent in sight. At almost the same hour in São Paulo, a child the same age is walking to school holding an adult's hand, and will keep holding it for several more years. Neither scene looks strange to the people living inside it.

Japanese parenting has a name for this early trust: *jiritsu* (自立), independence built on purpose, starting young. Elementary schools **make** first-graders carry their own trays, serve their own lunch, and clean their own classroom — no staff assigned to it. A famous television show, *Hajimete no Otsukai* ("My First Errand"), simply films toddlers doing exactly that: their first solo errand to a shop down the street. A parent might **help** a child pack the school bag the night before, but quietly, by six, that help stops.

Brazilian parenting tells a different story about love. Affection is physical and constant — *colo* (being held, carried, kept close) is practically a value in itself, not just something babies need. Parents don't **let** a six-year-old ride the metro alone, not because they don't trust the child, but because closeness is the point, not an obstacle to grow out of. It sometimes **gets** visiting foreigners to ask, gently, if Brazilian kids are ever put down.

Grandparents, aunts, and family friends are woven into the system early. A mother in Rio might **have** her own mother pick the kids up from school twice a week — not because she's too busy, but because that's what a family is for. In Japan, the neighborhood itself often plays that role instead: a shopkeeper who makes sure a small customer gets home safely is usually enough.

"Neither country is wrong. They're just answering a different question."

By the time a Japanese child is ten, the walk to school has already **made** her comfortable reading a train map alone. By the time a Brazilian child is ten, the walk to school has usually **made** him fluent in a different skill: knowing exactly which uncle to call if he needs a ride.

What both countries seem to agree on, in the end, is that a child eventually has to be trusted — with a task, with a walk, with a choice. They just disagree about the calendar. Japan tends to trust early and expects the

VOCABULARY

errand

お使い
recado, tarefa

trust

信頼
confiança

closeness

親密さ
proximidade, apego

independence

自立
independência

neighborhood

近所
vizinhança

to grow into (something)

～に成長して適応する
crescer até se adaptar

woven into

織り込まれた
entrelaçado, parte de

on its own time

自然な時間で
no seu próprio tempo

child to grow into it. Brazil tends to hold on longer, trusting that letting go, when it finally happens, will happen on its own time.



Independence, Japanese-style: trained early, in small doses — a lunch tray, an errand, a subway ride.



Closeness, Brazilian-style: the value itself, not a phase to outgrow.



Two calendars, one destination: a child who can eventually be trusted alone.

STRUCTURE SPOTLIGHT

Five ways to say someone caused someone else to act.

CASE	STRUCTURE	MEANING	EXAMPLE
MAKE	make + object + base verb / adjective	force — no choice	Schools make first-graders carry their own trays.
LET	let + object + base verb	permission — full choice	Parents don't let a six-year-old ride alone.
GET	get + object + to + verb	persuade — takes effort	It gets visiting foreigners to ask questions.
HAVE	have + object + base verb	arrange — it's their role	A mother might have her own mother pick the kids up.
HELP	help + object + (to) + verb	assist — together	A parent might help a child pack the bag.

NEXT PAGE →

COMPREHENSION CHECK

Answer based on the text. No need for full sentences.

1. True or False: In the opening scene, the child on the subway is not supervised by any adult. ☐ T ☐ F

2. What Japanese word does the text use for "independence"?

3. True or False: According to the text, Brazilian parents see closeness as an obstacle to overcome. ☐ T ☐ F

4. What example does the text give of the Japanese neighborhood playing a parenting role?

5. According to the text, what does a Japanese parent typically stop doing by the time the child is six?

6. True or False: By age ten in the text's example, the Brazilian child has learned to read a train map alone. ☐ T ☐ F

DISCUSSION

No right answer. Use the target verbs if you can.

1. Was there a moment in your own childhood when a parent finally let you do something alone? What was it?

2. Which idea from the text would you use to explain wabi-sabi-style patience to a Japanese friend — the Brazilian side, or does it not apply?

NEXT PAGE → ANSWER KEY

ANSWER KEY

Comprehension check — try first, check after.

1. True — The text says: no parent in sight.
2. jiritsu (自立)
3. False — Closeness is described as the point, not an obstacle.
4. A shopkeeper who makes sure a small customer gets home safely.
5. Helping pack the school bag the night before.
6. False — That's the Japanese example — the Brazilian child learns which uncle to call for a ride.

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